

Mark Word Preached

doc-mark-word-preached

Ecclesiology · Nature of the Church · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

breadth canon-wide

directness direct

variants stable

Statement under examination

Right preaching of the Word is a mark of a true visible church.

In plain language

The verses behind this proposition tie the gathered church tightly to the preaching, reading, and teaching of God's word, and the pattern runs through the whole Bible. In Second Timothy 4:2 the very first words are a direct command, 'preach the word' (keryxon ton logon), where the verb is a command form and 'word' (logos) is its object, followed at once by reprove, rebuke, exhort, and teach. Romans 10:14 to 17 builds a chain from calling to believing to hearing to a sent preacher and ends by saying faith comes from hearing, and hearing through the word ('spoken utterance', rhema), so where the word is not proclaimed the faith that makes a church cannot arise. Acts 2:42 reports the first believers continually devoting themselves to the apostles' 'teaching' (didache), named first among their habitual practices. First Timothy 4:13 tells the minister to give himself to the public reading, to 'exhortation' (paraklesis), and to 'teaching' (didaskalia), and Titus 1:9 requires an elder to hold the faithful word so he can teach and refute. The same vocabulary fills the Old Testament. The 'word' of God (dabar), the verb 'to hear' (shama), the act of proclaiming or reading aloud, and the instruction of the 'law' (torah) all occur thousands of times, the people are gathered in Deuteronomy and Nehemiah to hear the law read so they can understand and obey, and Jeremiah commands the prophet who has God's word to speak it faithfully. Taken together the words make the spoken and taught word a central, commanded activity of a real assembly, not an optional feature. One point keeps the confidence at medium. A direct search of the text found that no verse anywhere pairs the word for church/assembly (ekklesia) with any word for sign or mark (semeion). So the strong substance, that the word is central and constitutive, is plainly in the text, but the further idea of calling this a formal mark that sorts a true church from a false one is a summary drawn from the texts rather than something any single word states, and that part is held with more caution while the underlying claim stands firmly on the lexical evidence.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H1697	דָּבָר	dabar	word	1,368
H3925	לָמַד	lamad	to learn	
H7121	קָרָא	qara	to call	
H8085	שָׁמַע	shama	to hear	1,066
H8451	תּוֹרָה	torah	instruction	
G0225	ἀλήθεια	alētheia	truth	
G0320	ἀνάγνωσις	anagnōsis	reading	
G0652	ἀπόστολος	apostolos	apostle	

G1319	διδασκαλία	didaskalia	teaching	21
G1321	διδάσκω	didasko	to teach	96
G1322	διδαχή	didache	teaching	30
G1577	ἐκκλησία	ekklesia	assembly	115
G2097	εὐαγγελίζομαι	euangelizomai	to speak good news	
G2098	εὐαγγέλιον	euangelion	gospel	
G2727	κατηχέω	katēcheō	to instruct	
G2782	κήρυγμα	kērugma	preaching	
G2784	κηρύσσω	kerysso	to preach	61
G2980	λαλέω	laleō	to speak	
G3056	λόγος	logos	word	332
G3870	παρακαλέω	parakaleō	to plead/comfort	
G3874	παράκλησις	paraklēsis	encouragement	
G4487	ῥῆμα	rhēma	declaration	
G4592	σημεῖον	sēmeion	sign	

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The proclamation and teaching of the word is commanded as central to the gathered people of God across the whole canon. In 2 Timothy 4:2 the phrase 'preach the word' (keryxon ton logon), built from 'I proclaim' (kerysso, G2784) in the form of a direct command for completed past action (an aorist imperative) governing 'word' (logos, G3056), is a direct command to preach the word. Romans 10:14 to 17 makes faith arise 'from hearing through the word' (ex akoes dia rhematos), that is, by hearing through the word. Acts 2:42 reports the first community devoting itself to the apostles' 'teaching' (didache, G1322). The same vocabulary fills the Old Testament, with 'word' (dabar, H1697, occurring 1368 times), the public reading of the 'law' (torah) to the assembled people in Deuteronomy 31:11 to 12 and Nehemiah 8:8, and the prophet commanded to speak God's word faithfully in Jeremiah 23:28. Confidence is medium not because the centrality of the word is weak, but because no verse pairs 'church/assembly' (ekklesia, G1577) with any sign or mark term (the word for 'sign', semeion G4592, never co-occurs with ekklesia G1577), so the specific framing of preaching as a formal note distinguishing a true church from a false one is a synthesis the vocabulary supports in substance but does not itself enumerate.

Scripture

2Tim.4.2 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2784 κηρύσσω, G3056 λόγος, G1322 διδαχή

Force. The verse opens with 'preach the word' (keryxon ton logon), where 'preach' (keryxon) is a direct command form, second-person singular, for completed past action (an aorist active imperative second singular) of 'I proclaim' (kerysso, G2784=V-AAM-2S), and 'word' (logon) is its direct object in the form that receives the action (the accusative, G3056=N-ASM). This is a direct command to preach the word, followed by reprove, rebuke, and exhort in all patience and 'teaching' (didache, G1322). The grammar gives the strongest possible form of the obligation: not a description of what some did, but a command laid on the one who serves the assembly. The clustering of preaching, teaching, and exhortation in a single charge makes the ministry of the word the named duty.

Rom.10.17 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4487 ῥῆμα, G2784 κηρύσσω

Force. The chain of Romans 10:14 to 17 runs from calling to believing to hearing to a preacher, where the one preaching is 'I proclaim' (kerysso) as an ongoing-action participle in the 'of-the-X' form (a present active participle in the genitive, G2784=V-PAP-GSM) and the act of preaching is in a 'might-do' form for completed action by a plural subject (an aorist subjunctive third plural, G2784=V-AAS-3P) conditioned on being sent. Verse 17 concludes 'so faith comes from hearing, and hearing through the word' (ara he pistis ex akoes, he de akoe dia rhematos), where 'word' is 'spoken utterance' (rhema, G4487=N-GSN, a noun in the 'of-the-X' grammatical form). The grammar makes the preached word the necessary cause of faith, so a community in which the word is not proclaimed cannot generate the faith that constitutes it.

Acts.2.42 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G1322 διδασχῇ, G0652 ἀπόστολος

Force. The gathered believers were continually devoting themselves to the 'teaching' (didache) of the apostles, listed first among the habitual devotions of the new community alongside fellowship, breaking of bread, and prayers. The apostolic teaching heads the list and is described as a sustained activity, presenting the taught word as a constitutive (defining and essential) practice of the assembled church rather than an optional supplement.

1Tim.4.13 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1319 διδασκαλία, G3874 παράκλησις

Force. Timothy is told to devote himself to 'public reading' (anagnosis), to 'exhortation' (paraklesis, G3874), and to 'teaching' (didaskalia, G1319), three nouns in the 'to/for-X' form (datives) governed by the command 'pay attention to' (proseche). These are named as the standing public activities the minister owes the church until Christ comes. The triad of reading, exhortation, and teaching describes the verbal ministry of the word as the ordered work of the assembly's leadership.

Titus.1.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3056 λόγος, G1319 διδασκαλία

Force. The elder must hold fast 'the faithful word that accords with the teaching' (tou kata ten didachen pistou logou), so that he is able both to exhort in sound 'teaching' (didaskalia, G1319) and to refute those who contradict. Right teaching is written into the qualification for the very officers who order a church, so the appointment of leadership in Titus 1:5 is tied directly to fidelity in the word here in verse 9.

1Tim.3.15 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G1577 ἐκκλησία, G0225 ἀλήθεια

Force. The 'church/assembly' (ekklesia) of the living God is called the 'pillar' (stylos) and 'support/foundation' (hedraioma) of 'the truth' (aletheia, G0225). The building metaphor casts the assembly's defining function as upholding and displaying the truth, which presupposes that truth is being declared and taught within it. This is the closest the vocabulary comes to a defining role for the church, and it is stated in terms of the truth it bears, not in terms of a formal mark that sorts true from false assemblies.

1Cor.14.19 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1577 ἐκκλησία, G3056 λόγος

Force. This is the one verse in the canon where 'church/assembly' (ekklesia, G1577=N-DSF, a noun in the 'to/in-X' form) and 'word' (logos, G3056) stand together: 'in the assembly' (en ekklesia), Paul would rather speak five intelligible words that he might 'instruct' others (katecheo, G2727=V-AAS-1S, in a 'might-do' completed-action first-singular form). The pairing ties the spoken, understood word directly to the gathered church and grounds it in the goal of instruction, which is exactly the activity the proposition names.

Deut.31.12 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H8085 שמע, H8451 תנרה

Force. Israel is commanded to 'assemble' (haqhel) the people, men, women, children, and the sojourner, that they may 'hear' (shama, H8085) and 'learn' (lamad) and fear the LORD and keep the words of the 'law/instruction' (torah, H8451). The verse joins the gathered assembly directly to the public hearing and learning of God's word, showing the same constitutive (defining and essential) role for the word among the Old Testament people as the New Testament gives the church.

Jer.23.28 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H1697 דבר

Force. The prophet who has God's word is commanded to speak that word faithfully, 'let him speak my word in truth' (yedabber debari emeth), set against the one who tells his own dream. The verse fixes faithfulness of the spoken 'word' (dabar, H1697) as the standard for the true messenger, the Old Testament counterpart to the New Testament charge to preach the word, which is why the cross-reference apparatus links it to Romans 10:17 on the keyword of hearing.

Matt.18.20 · neutral · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1577 ἐκκλησία

Force. Christ promises to be present where two or three gather in his name. Read alone the verse could be taken to make bare gathering sufficient for a true assembly apart from any proclamation, but its setting is church discipline grounded in the binding and loosing of verses 18 and 19, which presupposes a community acting on a declared standard. The verse therefore does not displace the word but assumes it, so it is treated here as a text that does not directly weigh either way.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
2Tim.4.2	Ps.40.9	tsk	1
2Tim.4.2	Col.1.28	tsk	1
2Tim.4.2	1Tim.4.13	tsk	1
Rom.10.17	Jer.23.28	tsk	1
1Tim.3.15	Jer.1.18	tsk	1
1Tim.3.15	1Tim.3.2	tsk	1
Acts.2.42	Acts.20.7	tsk	1
Titus.1.5	Acts.14.23	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Matt.18.20 · addressed

The promise that Christ is present where two or three gather in his name could be read to make mere gathering, apart from any proclamation, sufficient for a true assembly. Its immediate context is church discipline grounded in the binding and loosing of verses 18 and 19, which presupposes a community acting on a declared standard, so the verse assumes rather than replaces the role of the word.

Acts.2.42 · addressed

The verse lists 'teaching' (didache) alongside fellowship, breaking of bread, and prayer, which could suggest teaching is only one of four parallel and equally optional items. The four are presented as habitual devotions that together describe the church, and 'teaching' (didache) heads the list, so the data supports teaching as constitutive (defining and essential) rather than dispensable.

1Tim.3.15 · unaddressed

This verse comes closest to a defining role for the church by calling it the pillar and support of the truth, but it states that role in terms of the truth the church upholds, not in terms of a sign or mark that distinguishes a true church from a false one. The lexical search found no verse anywhere in the canon that pairs 'church/assembly' (ekklesia, G1577) with a sign or mark term (the word for 'sign', semeion G4592), so the specific 'marks of the church' (notae ecclesiae) framing in the proposition cannot be resolved to a stated lexical category. It is left unaddressed at the level of the words because the vocabulary supports the substance but does not supply the formal mark concept.

Concordance traversed

G2784, G2782, G3056, G4487, G1322, G1321, G1319, G2097, G2098, G2980, G3870, G3874, G0320, G1577, G0225, G4592, G2727, H1697, H8085, H7121, H8451, H3925

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

The cited verses fall outside the open-cbqm 3 John sample, so CBGM (Coherence-Based Genealogical Method, a tool for tracing manuscript relationships) data was not examined and ecm_status (the status in the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) is shadow rather than published. The apparatus marks present in the bundle at Acts 2:42, Matthew 28:19 to 20, Matthew 18:15 to 19, Romans 10:14 to 15, and Titus 1:5 concern word order and minor readings that do not touch the words for preaching, word, teaching, or church, so they do not move the verdict.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

constitutive-activity-reading: affirms · Reading the proposition as the claim that preaching and teaching the word is a central, commanded, constitutive (defining and essential) activity of a true assembly yields direct and strong support. The command 'preach the word' (keryxon ton logon) in 2 Timothy 4:2, the faith from hearing of Romans 10:17, the apostolic 'teaching' (didache) of Acts 2:42, the reading, exhortation, and teaching triad of 1 Timothy 4:13, and the public reading of the 'law' (torah) in Deuteronomy 31:12 and Nehemiah 8:8 converge on the word as the indispensable verbal ministry of the gathered people.

formal-marks-taxonomy: partial · Reading the proposition strictly as asserting a formal note or sign that distinguishes a true visible church from a false one finds the underlying substance in the texts but no single word that erects the mark as a juridical test. No verse pairs 'church/assembly' (ekklesia) with a sign or mark word, so on this reading the proposition is an inference drawn from the constitutive (defining and essential) data rather than a stated category, which a reader holding to a strict marks taxonomy should recognize as a synthesis above the word level.

minimal-gathering-reading: partial · A reader who weights Matthew 18:20 most heavily could argue that the presence of Christ among two or three gathered in his name is what makes an assembly real, with the word important but not erected as a defining mark. Stated in its strongest form this reading is honest about the verse, but the surrounding discipline context and the canon-wide insistence that faith comes by the heard word mean the gathering it describes already presupposes a declared standard rather than dispensing with proclamation.

The verdict rests on the convergence of many texts across both Testaments ('analogy of Scripture', analogia scripturae, the principle that Scripture interprets Scripture): the preaching command of 2 Timothy 4:2, the faith from hearing of Romans 10:14 to 17, the apostolic teaching of Acts 2:42, the verbal ministry triad of 1 Timothy 4:13, the

elder qualification of Titus 1:9, the pillar of truth identity of 1 Timothy 3:15, the word in the assembly of 1 Corinthians 14:19, and the Old Testament public reading and prophetic faithfulness of Deuteronomy 31:12, Nehemiah 8:8, and Jeremiah 23:28. Progressive revelation (the principle that God's truth unfolds across the Bible) is in play because the Old Testament reading of the 'law' (torah) to the assembly is fulfilled and intensified in the New Testament command to preach the word, the same pattern carried forward.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. The proclamation, reading, and teaching of God's word is presented in the cited texts as a central and commanded activity of the gathered people of God.

The phrase 'mark of a true visible church' imports a formal 'marks of the church' taxonomy (notae ecclesiae, the confessional category of defining signs that sort true from false churches) that frames the claim as a distinguishing test between true and false churches. A direct lexical search confirmed that no verse in the canon pairs 'church/assembly' (ekklesia, G1577) with any sign or mark term (the word for 'sign', semeion G4592), so the mark-versus-counterfeit framing is a confessional synthesis that no single word supplies. The lexical data strongly supports the underlying claim that the proclaimed and taught word is central and constitutive (defining and essential) to the assembly, so the verdict on the original stem is affirms at medium confidence: the substance is lexically secure, the formal mark category is an inference held with caution. The verdict was derived on the original stem.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	2Tim.4.2
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Rom.10.17
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.14.19
morphology	STEPBible-TAHOT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Deut.31.12
lexicon	STEPBible-TAHOT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H1697
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Rom.10.17
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	2Tim.4.2

License audit

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Source	License	Redistribute
STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes
MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TAHOT	CC-BY-4.0	yes
TSK	public_domain	yes

Flags

ecm-shadow · complicating-unresolved